Sumukhi Suresh—stand-up comedian, actor, writer, and producer—is the kind of entertainer whose comic timing always has main character energy, whether she's crafting zingers for a film, stealing scenes on a Netflix show, or holding court on stage. In the last year alone, she's written dialogues for Vikramaditya Motwane's *CTRL*, lit up Netflix's *The Royals* as Keerthana, the charmingly chaotic assistant to Bhumi Pednekar's girlboss Sophia, and taken her stand-up special *Hormonal* on a wildly successful tour across India. And on June 7, she brings the curtain down on her tour, performing the last show at NMACC in Mumbai.

A candid take on hormonal chaos, singlehood and the existential dread that awaits women in their 30s, Sumukhi describes *Hormonal* as "an emotional breakdown, but with a laugh track". Raw, hilarious, and unmistakably personal, the 37-year-old comedian first started writing the show during the pandemic. But the idea itself was born out of heartbreak—specifically, the demise of a 10-year relationship on her 30th birthday—and grew to encompass the physical and emotional toll of PCOS, a condition she has battled since adolescence. To Sumukhi, making peace with the chaos of hormonal imbalance felt just as powerful a starting point as dismantling the constant fear society instils in single women about dying alone.

> Raw, hilarious and personal, the show is **Sumukhi's candid take** on hormonal chaos, singlehood and the existential dread

Perhaps that's why *Hormonal* feels equal parts catharsis and comedy and the show's poster goes all in to drive that point home. In it, Sumukhi strikes a Frida Kahlo-inspired pose, complete with floral crown and bold unibrow, a nod to the artist who made pain and beauty inseparable. In many ways, that's also the essence of Sumukhi's show—except in her case, the brushstrokes are punchlines. Pain can be funny. And funny can, after all, be revolutionary. ■

—Poulomi Das



VIVEK VENKATRAMAN

COCK is being staged on June 6 at Max Mueller, New Delhi, and on June 10 at Prithvi Theatre, Mumbai

these years later, the play is being revived by the duo, but with a new cast and a fresh perspective brought on with life's experiences.

The play, written in 2009, centres around John, who while on a break with his boyfriend M, falls in love with a woman W. Torn between these two loves and two identities, he struggles to make a decision. Tripathi, who first heard of the play from Gandhi back when they met at a theatre residency, was interested in the subject because of its multiple layers and the questions it raises. "The one thing I want to do with the plays I produce is to spark conversations. I want us to be uncomfortable and not shy away from the questions that we should be asking. Why are we so quick to judge people, based on their gender or sexuality or size? We don't talk about feelings. We get stuck in changing others according to how we feel they should be," says Tripathi, who believes that the play speaks to everyone, regardless of who they are.

With growing conversations around sexuality, gender and the pressure to define oneself, the makers felt that the questions raised by the play are even more relevant today than they were more than a decade ago. "Earlier, I was more interested in the design aspect of the play, but now it is the relationships and how people affect each other with what they say and how they receive that information is what I have focused on more," says Gandhi. Conversations around race, gender and sexuality in popular culture in the past couple of years have also coloured his perspective this time, he adds. Gandhi has not felt the need to adapt it to an Indian setting as he feels that a well-written script is universally accessible. The new cast includes Rytasha Rathore, Tanmay Dhanania, Sahir Mehta and Harssh Singh. ■

— Deepali Dhingra